



BEFORE

In previous wars, commanders had relied on messages being hand-delivered. By the outbreak of the Civil War, civilian telegraph services could send messages by wire.



THE PONY EXPRESS

PREWAR TELEGRAPHY

Using special codes to send messages over long distances, the telegraph was not a new technology in 1861, having existed since the 1840s. More than 50,000 miles (80,467km) of wire were already in place when war broke out, with 1,400 stations employing 10,000 people. The famous **Pony Express**, which was set up in April 1860 to provide a fast mail service between the East and West coasts, **was put out of business** by a transcontinental telegraph line that was completed in fall 1861.

Like the railroad, **nearly all telegraph infrastructure and investment was located in the Northern states**, with only about 10 percent delegated to the South. However, what did exist there was immediately put to use.

Following in the wake of the Union and Confederate armies were the telegraph services, putting up the poles and wires needed for sending messages to and from the front. The telegraph system allowed commanders-in-chief based far from the battlefield to exercise direct control over operational and even tactical events, and